



Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

Lesson 1: The Thanksgiving Prayer and Verses of Cymbals

Introduction and Thanksgiving Prayer

Revelations 8:3; "Then another angel, having a golden censer, came and stood at the altar. And he was given much incense, that he should offer it, with the prayers of all the saints upon the golden altar before the throne.

Raising Incense is an old church practice, not a pagan one.

We offer Incense before every liturgy, every day of the year except during Pascha Week.

We raise Incense in the afternoon, and in the morning, we call the afternoon raising of Incense **Vespers** and the morning one **Matins**.

NOTE: The Raising of Incense may be performed on its own, not just as an introduction to the Liturgy, but as an offer of the sacrifices of prayer and praise to God through its sweet incense.

The priest uncovers his head, opens the curtains, and says, "Have mercy on us, O God, the Father, the Pantocrator."

He then worships in front of the altar (facing the altar), offering praise and thanksgiving to God, and prostrates (worships) towards the people while asking for forgiveness.

He prays the Thanksgiving Prayer, which is prayed at the start of every service (Vespers, Matins, Liturgy, Weddings, Funerals, etc.)

During the prayer, the Deacon has three responses. Initially, he calls the people to "Stand up for Prayer" | **Ἐπιπροσεύχη**
ἵστασθε.

It is worth mentioning that every ritual exercise practiced by the congregation, whether it is prayer, standing or kneeling, or prostration, or listening, or leaving, always begins with a call from the deacon addressed to the people.

The Deacon also calls the people to "Pray" | **Προσεύχασθε...** and the response "Pray that God may have mercy", and the people respond with Lord Have Mercy.

After the conclusion of it, he prostrates at the door of the altar and enters the altar.



The Verses of Cymbals

We call this hymn the Verses of Cymbals because it is chanted with the use of the Cymbals.

A Verse in the Coptic church's hymns is a paragraph consisting of four 'stikhons', that is, four melodic sentences.

There are 3 tunes for the Verses of Cymbals, there is the standard tune, which is the most common, the festive tune which is said on the Feasts and the Hymn called the Lenten Kurie 'elehcon, which is only said during the weekdays of Lent and Jonah's Fast.

The Standard Tune:

In the standard days, the Verses of Cymbals go as follows:



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Introduction:

There are two introductions to the Verses of Cymbals, Adam Parts and Watos Parts, but both are said in the same standard tune.

The Adam Parts are said on Sunday-Tuesday while the Watos parts are on Wednesday-Saturday.

Parts for St.Mary and Heavenlies: St. Mary, Archangels, Cherubim , John the Baptist,etc.

Parts for the Apostles: Apostles, St.Mark,etc.

Parts for the Martyrs: St.Stephen, St.George,St.Philopatir,etc..

Parts for the Saints: St.Anthony,St.Paul , etc.

Conclusion: Through the intercession... , That we may praise you..

*Note: The Verses said can vary from church to church, depending on their parish name, but this is the order that follows.

The Festive Tune:

Said on days of Feasts, each feast with its respective verses.

The Feasts of Nativity, Theophany, and Resurrection precede with the Morning Doxology before the feast's respective parts, and then we continue as usual.

After the feasts parts, we continue with the Verses as follows, but conclude with the Festive Conclusion (ΙΗΣ ΠΧΣ ΗΣΑΥΝΕΜΦΘΟΥ) .

The Lenten Tune:

A Hymn consisting of the words Lord Have Mercy known as the Lenten ΚΥΡΙΕ ΕΛΕΗΣΟΝ.

During the Lenten weekdays, we do not play the cymbals due to their asceticism, so therefore, the Verses of Cymbals are not chanted.

- **Points to Review:**

- **Overview of Incense in the Church**
- **Thanksgiving Prayer**
- **Verses of Cymbals Tunes and Order**